‘monument symbolism’ appears to have ‘outlived its shelf-life’.[59] Simultaneously, the party reduced the representational opportunities it once offered to Dalit politicians. This shift, in the absence of a clear Dalit party alternative, opened up new opportunities for the BJP as it looked to pick up non-Jatav votes.

Much is made of the BJP being the richest party in India (as Chapter 7 details). Yet, this change in the central BJP coffers happened after it came to power in 2014. Until 2014, it was the Congress that had the money advantage. At the level of candidates, the BJP’s UP candidates were actually the second-poorest among major state parties in 2004 (2.67 per cent with assets above ₹5 crore) and the poorest (10.29 per cent with assets above ₹5 crore) in 2009 and 2014 (29.49 per cent). All through these years, the Congress, the SP to some extent, and the BSP to a much greater extent, fielded richer candidates than the BJP in UP during Lok Sabha polls.

Yes, the net worth of BJP candidates did increase substantially by 2019, when as many as half of its UP candidates were worth more than ₹5 crore—turning it into a party with the second most prosperous Lok Sabha candidates in the state by 2019. But this was still on par with the Congress (50.7 per cent), not too different from the SP (43.2 per cent) and much lower than the BSP (67.5 per cent). While the BJP did become a much richer party, in terms of the people it fielded, the proportion of rich candidates was still within the Indian average for political parties—unlike the BSP, which is way above that average.

This trend is also borne out at the national level. Across all Indian states, the BJP’s candidates with assets over ₹5 crore went from 2.72 per cent in 2004 to 29.67 per cent in 2014 and 43.18 per cent in 2019. By 2019, the BJP also became by far the richest party in India. This does give it structural advantages. But it is important to remember that this advantage only accrued to it by 2019. In individual candidate terms, the Congress, at the national level and on average, fielded richer candidates than the BJP, even in 2019. Nationwide, the number of its rich candidates was substantially higher than the BJP’s in 2014, double that of the BJP in 2009 and four times higher in 2004.